

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

IT Law

You already know that lawyers use such terms as 'hereinafter' 'wherefore' and so on. But what kinds of terms do IT lawyers use, under the Information Technology Act of 2000? Here's a sampler.

Computer: According to IT lawyers, this does not refer to the box you're so familiar with. It manipulates electronic, magnetic, or optical impulses, and for good measure, includes all input, output, processing, storage, and blah blah, that are connected—or even related—to the computer.

Access: No, this is not about usernames and passwords. Access is, as it turns out, "with its grammatical variations and cognate expressions," gaining entry into, instructing or communicating with the logical, arithmetical, or memory resources of a computer. Phew! Actually, there's more to it than that, but we didn't understand it. **Time and place of despatch and receipt of electronic record:** We doubt that even the lawyers understand this section of the Act. It says in the Act that the despatch of an electronic record occurs when it enters a computer resource "outside the control of the originator." This is something related to AI and robotics: computers communicating all by themselves, without human intervention...

Penalty for damages: It turns out that whatever damage you inflict upon a computer, you don't need to pay the owner more than Rs 1 crore. If you download a virus onto someone's computer, expect a lawyer to refer to it as "introducing, or causing to be introduced, any computer contaminant or virus into a computer." 'Contaminant'? Wonder what that means... **Residuary Penalty:** Whoever contravenes any rules or regulations under the IT Act is liable to pay Rs 25K to someone hurt by your activities! So next time someone makes your Windows crash, remember to ask him to shell out.

Digitisers In Distress

The bosses at Digit think they are god's gift to workaholism. So, on a balmy March afternoon, they lug us all the way to Khandala, to talk about various official things. It is called mixing business with pleasure, but we privately call it torture. Khandala is this cool, little hill station some 100 km north of Mumbai. And trust our guys to put us all in some claustrophobic conference room for three hours with biscuits for company. Credit to them, when they said three hours, they actually meant two, so we were out in two hours.

Anyway, the point of this story is not to grumble about the bosses—we can fill a whole new section on that someday—but to talk about the ineptness of some drivers. The worthy chap who was cabbing us to Khandala thought that just like a newly-married couple that lives on love and fresh air, his Toyota Qualis too

would live on two litres of diesel and will power until Khandala.

Sadly for him, and tragically for us, it did not. And we were stranded right in the middle of nowhere on the Mumbai-Pune Expressway. So there we were, nine people trying to get to the destination desperately, but helpless like a maiden in a Hindi film. Our man wanted fuel, and there was no fuel. The closest fuel station was 12 km away. The next 20 minutes looked and sounded like the Indian Parliament. There was much consternation, shouting, buck-passing, and ultimately one person even wanted to stage a walkout, only to be prevented by vehicles zipping at 120 Kmph along the expressway.

Ultimately, another driver, who dropped off the previous nine people, came back and picked us up, and took us to our destination, where we spent the aforementioned two hours inside the claustrophobic room.

DIGIT DIARY

an advanced smartphone or on a desktop computer, takes into account everything from weather, to sporting events, to accidents, in making its predictions. It also looks at traffic relationships—if, for example, a northbound freeway is jammed, it may be able to gauge the ease or difficulty of a westbound commute.

Sarin said at least 2,000 Microsoft employees are now using a prototype of the product in the Seattle area.

DEADBEATS AS CRIMINALS

Buyers Beware

Bay, with its massive reach and member base, can be the starting point for violent crimes as well. Dewan Horne, 24, was indicted early March by a US federal grand jury: he first auctioned vintage cars on eBay, cars he did not own, and then had two partners rob the would-be buyers at gunpoint. The partners are still at large.

In one of the robberies, which occurred in December, a father and son were forced, at gunpoint, to lie down. Horne and his partners then took more than \$9,000 (Rs 4 lakh) in cash and equipment from their truck before leaving in Horne's car.

Horne is charged with robbery and conspiracy under the Hobbs Act, which prohibits interference with interstate commerce by threats or violence, and for his partners' alleged use of firearms during the crimes. He could face prison time and a fine, if convicted, prosecutors said.

On eBay, though, Horne probably got away with just two negative ratings. If the people who were robbed, bothered to rate him, that is.



EDIBLE NANOTECH

Eat Your Silicon

Nanotech may soon find its way into your stomach. It's not about nanobots—tiny programmable robots; rather, it's about particles that could enhance the absorption of food and medicine—meaning programmable drinks and more effective drugs.

"We're creating nanoparticles that can assemble themselves and that are made of materials already found in food," said physicist Anthony Dinsmore at the University of Massachusetts in Amherst.

Edible nanoparticles can be made in a wide range of shapes, from spheres to pipes, and are composed of materials either relatively inert in the body, such as silicon or ceramics, or materials that react with the body's heat or chemistry, such as polymers.

A key advantage edible nanoparticles have over